

TREES

Dramatic and sculptural, trees are essential plants for gardens large and small. In design terms, they provide height, structure and year-round interest, with flowers, foliage, fruit, and attractive bark, while also offering a home and source of food for birds and other wildlife.

What are trees?

Trees are woody plants, with life spans ranging from decades to several centuries. There are deciduous and evergreen trees, and most have a single stem with a crown of branches, although some produce multiple stems, either naturally or as a result of pruning. They range in size from conifers that are less than 3ft (1m) in height, to forest giants that soar up to 300ft (90m) or more. Trees also vary in shape. Some are narrowly conical or columnar, others are rounded or spreading, while some have an elegant, arching, weeping habit. There is also a wide choice of leaf shape and color.

BELOW Letting in the light

Deciduous trees, such as *Acer shirasawanum* 'Aureum', can be used to make a wonderful garden centerpiece, underplanted with low plants to extend the interest before and after the main summer season.



Choosing trees

Before buying, match the needs of your chosen tree with the conditions in your garden. A tree is a long-term investment, so consider your site and soil carefully to ensure it will thrive, and that the size, shape, and style will suit your design scheme, since trees are difficult to move once established. Also calculate the amount of shade the tree will cast on your or your neighbor's garden when mature, and site large trees away from the house, and where their roots will not interfere with walls, pipes, drains or cables.

Designing with trees

Trees have many beautiful features and can be used in various ways to enhance a garden design. For example, several trees can be planted to form enclosures or define

SIZE CATEGORIES USED WITHIN THIS GROUP		
Large over 50ft (15m)	Medium 30–50ft (10–15m)	Small up to 30ft (10m)

spaces; they can be used in pairs to frame a view, or in rows to form an avenue or tunnel. A line of trees also provides excellent wind protection, and those that tolerate clipping, such as beech (*Fagus sylvatica*), hornbeam (*Carpinus betulus*), and yew (*Taxus baccata*), make attractive hedges that diffuse wind and noise.

Many trees have eye-catching features that make beautiful focal points—those with colorful stems and bark or large sculptural leaves make good choices. The shape and form of a tree can also help

REMOVING A TREE BRANCH

The best time to prune most trees is in late winter when the plants are dormant, but wait until mid- to late summer for hornbeam (*Carpinus*), pears (*Pyrus*), and plums and cherries (*Prunus*), which are susceptible to disease if cut earlier.



1 Make an undercut first

Shorten the branch first to reduce its weight and stop it from falling and tearing the bark. Cut halfway through the underside of the branch, then saw downward from the top, farther along the branch away from the trunk. Allow the branch to snap off.



2 Cut close to the trunk

Remove the final stump by cutting close to the trunk, but not flush with it. Make a smooth cut, angled away from the tree, just beyond the crease in the bark where the branch meets the trunk.